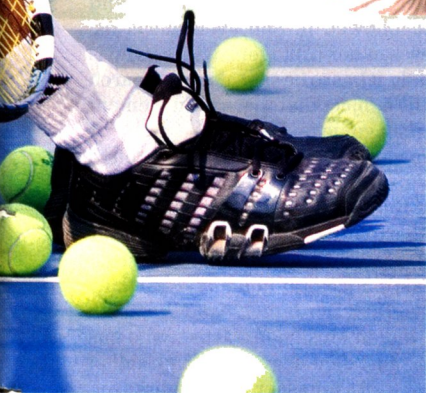


“ Growing up in a tennis family is the best thing—no one in the house is new to winning and losing. ”



YUKI BHAMBRI WITH (FROM LEFT) MOTHER INDU AND TENNIS-PLAYING SISTERS SANAA AND ANKITA



BANDEEP SINGH

years, the sport's brutal roulette wheel spun past them. Until this day when, with their youngest-born, the numbers finally fell in their favour.

Bhambri's sisters, Ankita, 22, and Sanaa, 20, are among the country's top women players who have been national champions in their own right. Promising teenagers themselves, they won titles on the ITF women's circuit events held in India (Ankita has eight singles and seven doubles titles, Sanaa two singles and nine doubles).

Chander would travel with his daughters, sometimes living in Rs 250-a-night hotel dumps wherever

the tennis tour pitched its tent, to keep the girls sharp and to squeeze every last ranking point out of every easily accessible tournament. And yet when it was time to head overseas for a better grade of competition to move up the rankings, the family ran into the concrete wall that had crushed many before them: funding.

Their coach Aditya Sachdeva says, "Not having resources is tough to deal with for any player with the capability and the want." Indu says, "We sent their bio-datas everywhere, went to everyone. Sometimes you couldn't get through a door; you felt like a beggar."

Naturally, the Bhambris wanted their son to keep a good distance from tennis. But one look at the 9-year-old's ball control and Sachdeva coaxed the parents to let him work with their son for free. Indu says, "The girls never got that push, but with Yuki, I don't know, it was just as if all the avenues just opened up." The day after their son's tennis costs threat-

ened to pull them under again, a casual court-side chat brought a phone call from Apollo Tyres and Yuki's first major sponsorship deal.

Ankita and Sanaa are now in Perth, playing on the Indian Fed Cup team, vastly amused at the tumult around their kid brother. Ankita says, "We've had a difficult journey as a family, but with Yuki, we wanted everything to be perfect, we wanted no mistakes."

As clinical as it sounds, it has meant major changes. The girls had lived on a strict regimen of tennis, training and studies, and were forbidden TV or a trip to the cinema hall till they were 18.

For Bhambri, though, tennis has always meant freedom. Indu says, "The girls never let us pressure him, he is totally relaxed about his tennis." At 14, he would tell himself, "Win today and you can skip school tomorrow for the next round." Growing up with tennis-playing sisters is he says "the best thing because no one in the house is new to winning and losing". It has taken a largeness of heart that the boy will fully understand much later. Sachdeva calls Ankita an "icon" for her siblings: "I have never seen her complain or show any frustration."

Today, while Chander works the computers and plans the travel, his wife is in charge of their son's career. The siblings speak to each other every day—sharing stories, talking tennis.

The most telling story of this family savouring a collective breakthrough comes from a bleak night about four years ago. As the youngest among them slept, Chander called his wife and two girls and showed them a thin stack of cash. Their bank account was empty. "This is it," he said, "this is what's left. What do we do?" The sport that had given his daughters their place in the world had bled the family dry. Indu remembers the moment well, the desolation of it, the hopelessness and what happened afterwards.

"Forget about my tennis," Sanaa said. In the same instant, Ankita spoke, "Give it to Yuki, let Yuki play."

So Yuki will play. For fulfilment, for fame, for fortune. But always, always, Yuki Bhambri will play for his family.